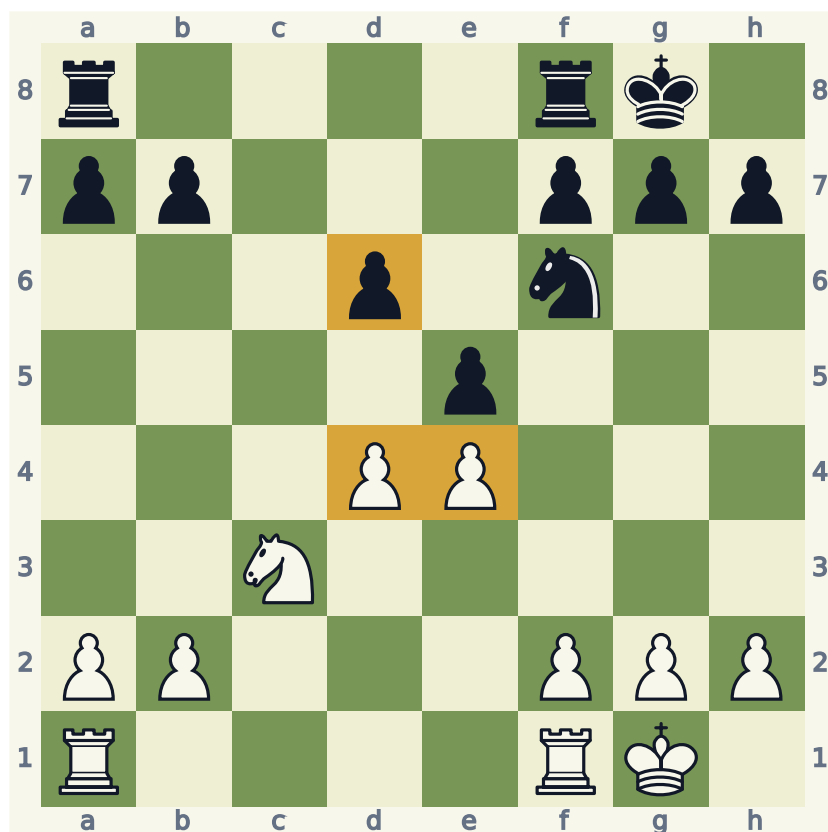


Evaluate, then make a plan

Turn visible facts into a useful next move.

A positional plan connects a feature of the board to a change you want to achieve. First rule out immediate threats. Then compare material, king safety, pawn structure and piece activity. Choose the most important imbalance; do not try to improve everything at once.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- Material is equal; both kings have a pawn shelter.
- White has more central space, but d4 is attacked by e5.
- The f1-rook can support d4 while the a1-rook stays flexible.

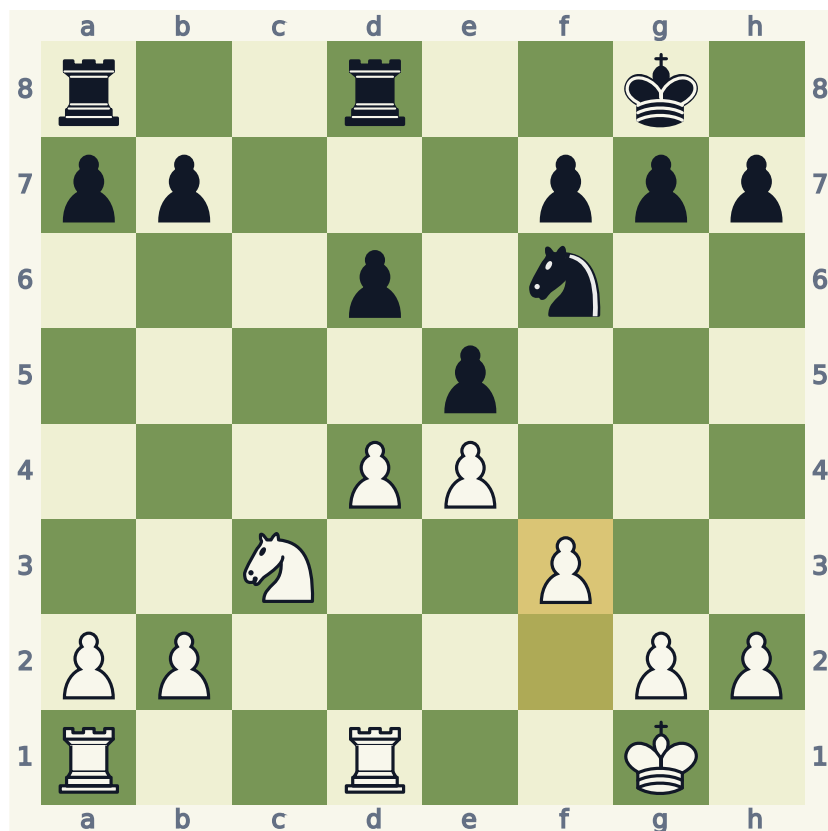
REMEMBER

- Threats first; plans second.
- State a fact, its consequence and a move.
- Reassess after every pawn exchange.

Follow the logic

1. Rfd1 Rfd8 2. f3

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Rfd1

Support the point of contact before expanding. A rook belongs on a file where a future exchange may open lines.

...Rfd8

Black gives d6 extra support. Compare the jobs of the rooks rather than counting developed pieces.

f3

White reinforces e4. This is useful here, but it also commits a pawn and reduces the king's cover.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black should examine ...exd4, ...d5 and exchanges that reduce White's space. A plan must survive a central change; a quiet rook move is not a promise that the center will stay closed.

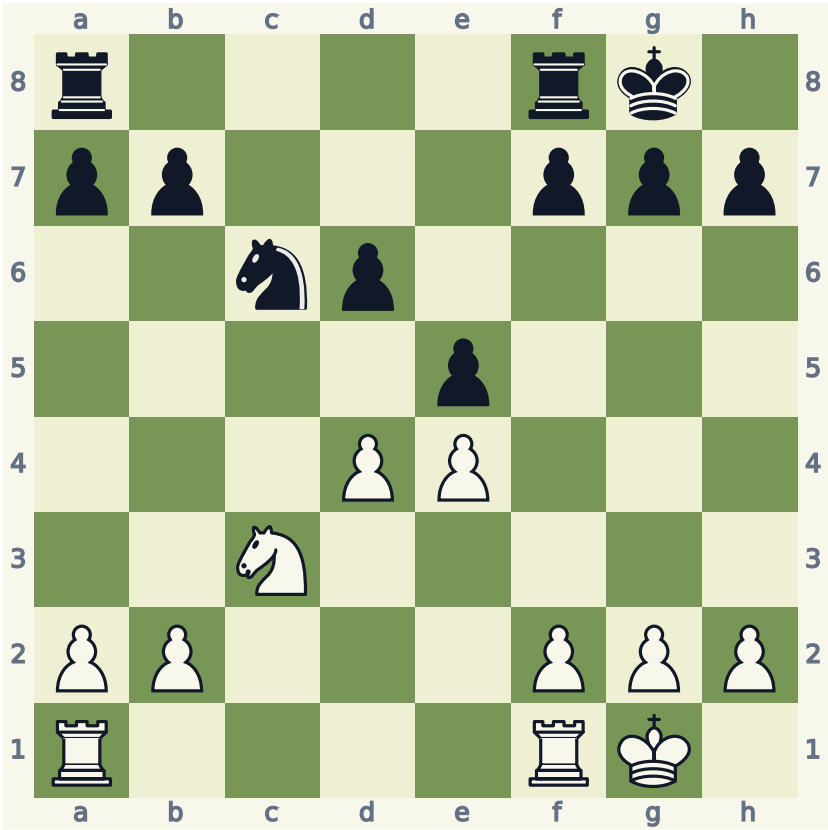
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Do not call White winning because of space. The central pawns can become targets. If a forcing threat appears, calculation takes priority over this planning routine.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Name two facts that matter more than a general desire to attack.
- 2. Choose a useful rook move and explain the job it performs.
- 3. After the sample reply ...Rfd8, what changes if White plays d5?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

Suppose Black can open the center with tempo against your king. Does a slow improvement still come first?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): r4rk1/pp3ppp/2np4/4p3/3PP3/2N5/PP3PPP/R4RK1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. Material is level and the center is in contact: e5 attacks d4. White's space is meaningful, but the pawn base needs care. Neither king is under an immediate forcing attack in this reduced position.
2. Rfd1 adds support to d4 and anticipates an open d-file. Rad1 is also a legal candidate; choosing between rooks depends on which future files you expect to use. The exercise rewards a concrete reason, not a memorized rook rule.
3. d5 closes the d-file and attacks Nc6. The knight must find another square. White gains space but gives up the possibility of exchanging the d-pawn on e5. Reassess piece routes after changing the structure.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Rfd1 Rfd8 2. d5

Changed feature: No. Evaluate the forcing line before spending a tempo. A correct strategic diagnosis does not make a tactically unsafe move playable.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

In three of your own games, stop at move 15. Write one sentence beginning: Because ____, I want ____, so I will consider ____.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 02, 03, 05. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.